# The Winds of Change

Events in the Eastern bloc and GDR moved quickly that winter, leaving the SED staggering from one crisis to the other. Buoyed when independent parties began operating in Hungary, a silent march in Leipzig, ostensibly marking the 70th anniversary of the murder of Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxembourg on 15 January, morphed into an appeal ‘for the democratisation of our socialist state’. Watching events unfold, Stasi operatives described the march as a ‘political provocation’ orchestrated by church groups,1 notably Pastor Christoph Wonneberger’s congregation.

Out of touch, tune and temper, Honecker continued to obscure pro-democracy voices through a media blackout. In what seemed almost like an affront to public sentiment, he stated that the Berlin Wall would still exist in fifty and even in a hundred years’ time if the reasons for its presence had not been removed. ‘It is necessary to protect our republic from robbers, not to mention those who would like to disturb the stability and peace of Europe,’ he said, sounding every bit the old Stalinist. ‘The protection of borders is the sovereign right of every state, and thus also of the GDR.’2 Meanwhile, the economy blundered further toward bankruptcy. Stupefied by Honecker’s inactivity, Gerhard Schürer secretly met Egon Krenz at his Baltic Sea retreat in February to divulge details of the GDR’s crippling debts to the West which were increasing at a rate of over 500 million marks per month. He warned if this trend continued, East Germany could face insolvency by 1991. Krenz, though, was pre-occupied with a series of blistering headlines concerning new escape attempts appearing in the international media. When 20-year-old waiter Chris Gueffroy was shot while trying to flee at the Berlin Wall on the evening of 6 February, the Western Allies called the shooting a ‘crime against humanity’. Gueffroy had been desperately trying to scale the wall with a friend when spotted by border guards. Though the bullets fired at Gueffroy were the last fatal shots at the Berlin Wall, a month later, 32-year-old Winfried Freudenberg was killed after his homemade gas balloon fell from the sky over West Berlin, breaking nearly every bone in his body.